

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Financial Advice English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For financial advisors, planners, wealth-management teams, retirement specialists, paraplanners, and client-service staff.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

529 plan

Tax-advantaged education savings plan under U.S. rules, subject to program and tax details.

Alternative investment

Nontraditional investment that may have complexity, illiquidity, higher fees, or eligibility limits.

Annuity

Insurance contract that may provide income or guarantees with costs, restrictions, and conditions.

Asset allocation

Division of portfolio among asset categories such as equities, fixed income, cash, and alternatives.

AUM fee

Fee based on assets under management.

Behavior gap

Difference between investment returns and investor returns caused by timing and behavior.

Benchmark

Reference index or blend used to evaluate portfolio performance.

Beneficiary designation

Account instruction naming who receives assets after death, subject to account and legal rules.

Broker-dealer

A regulated firm or representative involved in securities transactions and recommendations.

Chasing performance

Buying what recently performed well without evaluating risk and fit.

Client objective

The goal the plan is designed to support, not necessarily the client's latest emotional reaction.

Commission

Transaction-based compensation connected to buying, selling, or placing a product.

Concentrated position

Large exposure to one security, employer stock, sector, or asset class.

Conflict of interest

A factor that could influence or appear to influence advice or recommendations.

Constraints

Limits such as income needs, legal restrictions, values preferences, concentration, liquidity, or tax concerns.

Disclose

Communicate relevant information about services, fees, risks, conflicts, or limitations.

Disclosure

Communication of relevant facts such as fees, risks, services, conflicts, and limitations.

Diversification

Spreading exposure across holdings or asset classes to reduce concentration risk.

Document

Record facts, rationale, alternatives, risks, client instructions, and follow-up.

Drawdown

Decline from a prior high value to a lower value.

Escalate

Raise an issue to compliance, supervision, legal, tax, or specialist support.

ETF

Exchange-traded fund; pooled investment traded on an exchange.

Expense ratio

Annual fund operating costs expressed as a percentage of assets.

Fee-only

Compensation model often meaning no product commissions, but definitions and use should be checked.

Fiduciary duty

Duty to act in the client's best interest under applicable standards and context.

Financial advisor

A broad market term for someone who provides financial guidance; legal meaning depends on registration, license, and services.

Financial plan

A coordinated view of goals, resources, assumptions, risks, and recommended actions.

Form ADV

Investment adviser disclosure and registration form, including brochure information for clients.

Form CRS

Relationship summary designed to help retail investors understand services, fees, conflicts, and disciplinary history.

Herding

Following others' decisions without independent analysis of fit and risk.

Investment adviser

A regulated adviser role that may owe fiduciary obligations under applicable law and registration status.

Investment experience

Client's familiarity with products, markets, risks, and prior investing decisions.

Investment objective

What the client is trying to accomplish, such as growth, income, preservation, or liquidity.

IPS

Investment policy statement connecting objectives, risk, allocation, constraints, and monitoring.

Liquidity need

Need for accessible cash or investments that can be sold without unacceptable cost or delay.

Load

Sales charge on certain mutual funds or products.

Loss aversion

Tendency to feel losses more strongly than similar gains.

Managed account

Account in which investments are managed for the client under an agreed program or mandate.

Monte Carlo analysis

Simulation showing possible goal outcomes under many market paths, not a guarantee.

Mutual fund

Pooled investment vehicle that issues shares and is typically priced at net asset value.

Panic selling

Selling primarily from fear during stress, often without revisiting goals and plan.

Rebalancing

Adjusting portfolio back toward target allocation after movement or client change.

Recency bias

Tendency to overweight recent events when making decisions.

Recommend

Suggest a specific action or strategy based on client facts and standards.

Refer

Direct the client to another qualified professional for tax, legal, insurance, or specialized advice.

Regulation Best Interest

SEC standard of conduct for broker-dealers when making recommendations to retail customers.

Retirement income

Cash flow used to support spending after work income decreases or stops.

Revenue sharing

Payment arrangement that may create a conflict requiring disclosure and management.

Risk capacity

The client's financial ability to absorb loss without derailing goals.

Risk tolerance

The client's emotional willingness to accept investment volatility or loss.

RMD

Required minimum distribution from certain retirement accounts under IRS rules, depending on age, account, and facts.

Roth conversion

Moving pre-tax retirement assets into Roth status, often creating tax considerations.

Sequence risk

Risk that early losses during withdrawals harm long-term sustainability.

Substantiate

Support a claim, recommendation, or statement with evidence or approved materials.

Suitability

A standard requiring recommendations to fit a customer's investment profile under applicable rules.

Supervise

Review and oversee advice, communication, accounts, and advisor activity under firm policy.

Surrender charge

Fee for withdrawing from certain products during a specified period.

Tax status

Client tax facts that may affect planning and investment decisions, requiring qualified tax guidance.

Tax-loss harvesting

Selling investments at a loss to potentially offset gains, subject to tax rules and constraints.

Time horizon

How long the client expects to invest before needing funds for a goal.

Tradeoff

Choice that improves one objective while accepting cost or risk somewhere else.

Update

Refresh client information, risk profile, beneficiary details, or planning assumptions.

Withdrawal rate

Percentage of a portfolio withdrawn over a period, often discussed in retirement income planning.

Wrap fee

Bundled fee covering advisory and certain transaction or platform services, depending on program.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

A prospective client says, "I want to retire comfortably." No spending estimate, target date, or current asset summary is available.

What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Standards of Conduct, Best Interest, Disclosures, and Conflicts

A client asks how a firm is paid. The adviser has the firm's current fee and relationship disclosures available.

Let's walk through the current disclosures together, including fees, services, and relevant conflicts. Which parts would you like me to explain? I can also show where the information is recorded.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Goals, Risk Profile, Asset Allocation, and IPS Language

A client describes themselves as comfortable with investment risk but says they need some funds for a house purchase next year.

When you say you're comfortable with risk, are you including the money needed next year? Let's distinguish your willingness to accept losses from your ability to absorb them for each goal.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Retirement Planning, Income, Tax-Aware Conversations, and RMDs

A retirement illustration assumes a fixed annual return. A client reads the chart as a promise of future income.

This is an illustration based on assumptions, not a guaranteed income path. Let's review how different returns and spending needs change the picture before discussing any planning decision.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Portfolio Reviews, Volatility, Rebalancing, and Behavioral Coaching

A client's statement shows a decline, and they want to know whether the change reflects withdrawals, fees, or market movement.

Let's separate the withdrawals, fees, and investment movement for the same period. That will explain the balance change more clearly than looking only at the opening and closing totals.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Products, Account Types, Rollovers, Annuities, Insurance, and Alternatives

A client is comparing two account options. One summary omits exit charges and ongoing service differences.

We need the same categories for both options: charges, services, restrictions, and relevant tax considerations. I'll use the current documents to build a comparable summary before we discuss suitability.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Family, Estate, Beneficiaries, Elder Risk, and Difficult Client Moments

A client asks how to review beneficiary details after a family change. The service team can explain the firm's process but cannot resolve legal questions.

We can help you review the beneficiary information held by the firm and explain the update process. For questions about legal effects or estate planning, let's identify the appropriate qualified adviser.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Practice Management, Documentation, Complaints, Marketing, and Supervision

A client says a service email did not answer their complaint. The record shows an acknowledgment but no response to the specific concern.

You're right that our earlier message did not address that concern. I'll record the issue accurately and confirm the next step in our complaints process, including when you should expect an update.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Financial Advice English

Professional audience: financial advisors, planners, wealth-management teams, retirement specialists, paraplanners, and client-service staff

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Advisor English: Discovery, Scope, Trust, and Boundaries

Original fictional case: A prospective client says, "I want to retire comfortably." No spending estimate, target date, or current asset summary is available.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Client objective: The goal the plan is designed to support, not necessarily the client's latest emotional reaction. / Investment objective: What the client is trying to accomplish, such as growth, income, preservation, or liquidity. / Financial plan: A coordinated view of goals, resources, assumptions, risks, and recommended actions. / Time horizon: How long the client expects to invest before needing funds for a goal.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What would a comfortable retirement look like for you? Could we start with your target date and expected spending? That will help us understand your goals before discussing possible approaches.

END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level